Colorado Retail Ammunition Market Analysis

Exploratory Pricing, Availability, and Lead vs. Lead-Free Comparisons

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Methods & Data Processing

Data Collection & Scope

- **Data Sources:** Pricing and catalog data were aggregated across major brick-and-mortar storefronts in Colorado and online retailers shipping directly into the state.
- **Regulation Alignment:** Full Metal Jacket (FMJ), match target ammunition, and solid non-expanding target rounds were filtered out to reflect projectiles legally permitted for big-game harvest under Colorado Parks and Wildlife (CPW) regulations (expanding/mushrooming bullets only).
- **Caliber Focus:** Analysis is restricted to a sampling of popular Colorado big-game centerfire rifle calibers, excluding rimfire, pistol cartridges, and bulk military-surplus chamberings.

Deduplication & Standardization

- **Product-Level Identity:** Individual listings were deduplicated across retailers using Universal Product Codes (UPC) and Manufacturer Part Numbers (MPN), falling back to title matching where identifiers were unlisted.
- **Temporal Freshness:** For retailers with repeat scrapes over time, only the most recent observed price per product was retained.
- **Pricing Unit:** All costs reflect factory loaded ammunition normalized to Price Per Round (USD/rd). Box counts (20-round standard hunting boxes vs. 50-round packages) were standardized by dividing total box price by box quantity prior to aggregation.

Dataset Overview

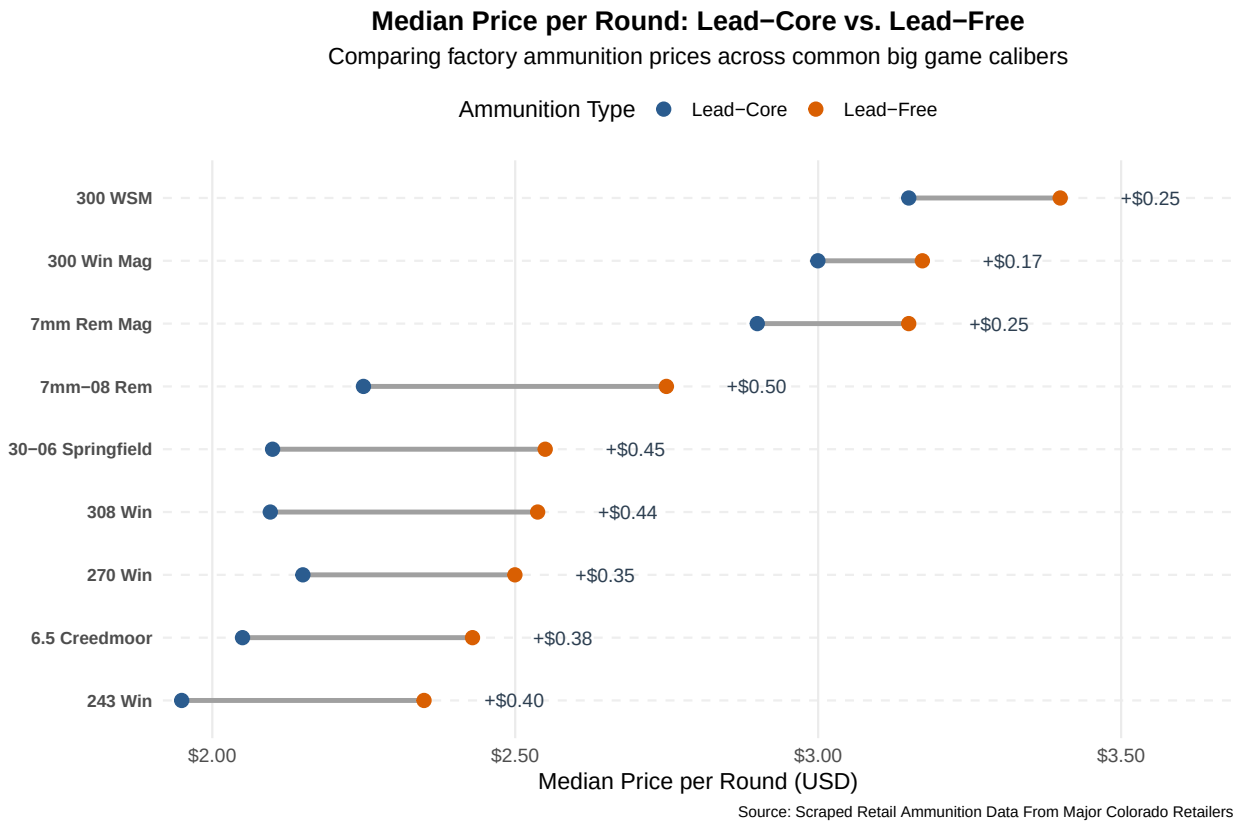
Table 1: High-Level Market Summary (USD per Round)

Total Listings	Mean PPR	Median PPR	Min PPR	Max PPR	IQR PPR
2101	2.45	2.35	0.8	7	0.9

Across all tracked calibers and retailers, the typical price per round sits at $2.35 - the median listed above. Because high-end rounds can pull the arithmetic mean upward, this report primarily relies on the **median** (the middle price on the shelf) to represent where everyday consumer costs likely sit.

Price Comparison: Lead vs. Lead-Free

Median Pricing Dumbbell Chart



How to read this chart:

- Each horizontal line represents a single caliber.
- The **blue dot** marks the median price of traditional lead-core rounds.
- The **orange dot** marks the median price of lead-free (copper/monolithic) rounds.
- The grey line between the two dots illustrates the price gap, with the dollar figure at the end indicating the median price difference per round.

Takeaway: Lead-free ammunition carries a consistent price surcharge across standard hunting calibers - generally between **+$0.35 and +$0.50 per round** (or roughly $7.00 to $10.00 more per 20-round box). In magnum cartridges (7mm Rem Mag, 300 Win Mag, .300 WSM), premium lead-core hunting loads approach price parity with lead-free offerings, sitting at a higher initial price per round in general.

Price Table

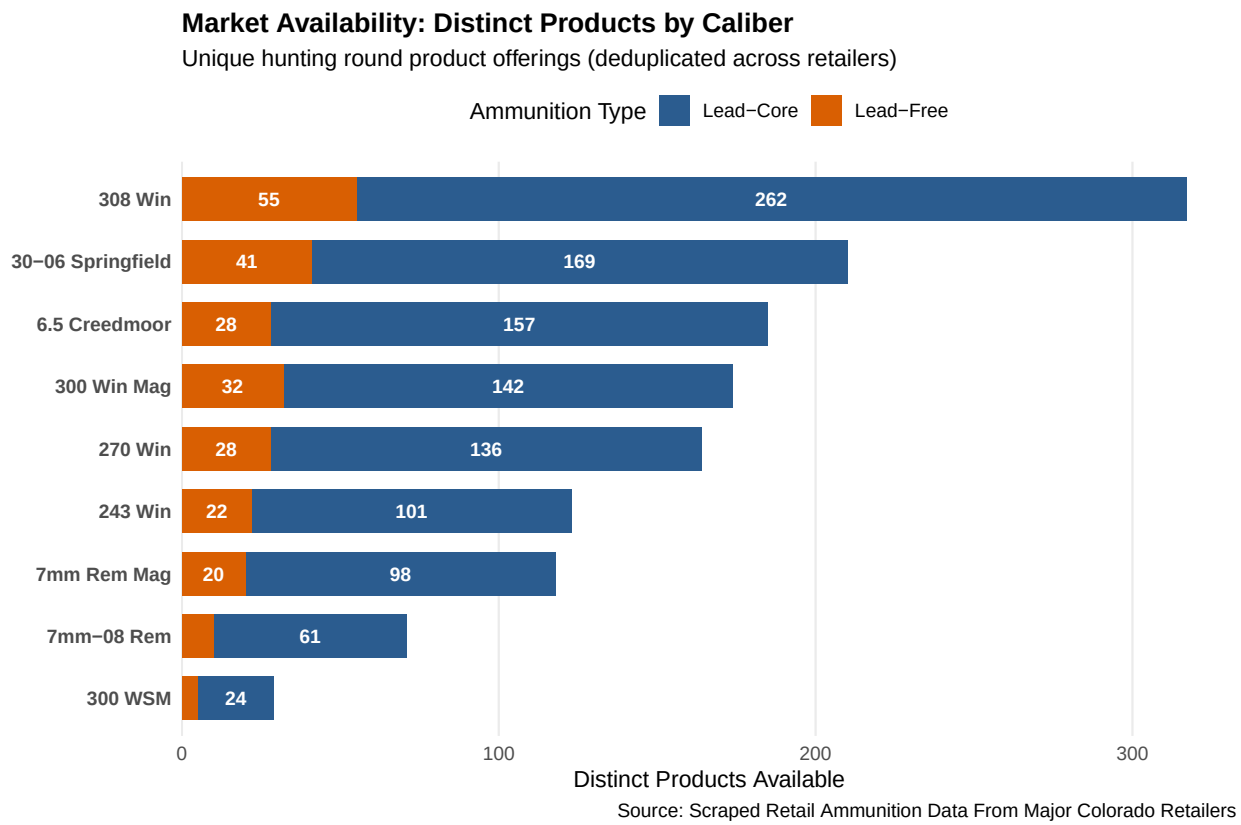
Table 2: Ammunition Pricing Comparison by Caliber

Caliber	Lead-Core ($/rd)	Lead-Free ($/rd)	Lead-Free Premium
300 WSM	$3.15	$3.40	+$0.25
300 Win Mag	$3.00	$3.17	+$0.17
7mm Rem Mag	$2.90	$3.15	+$0.25
7mm-08 Rem	$2.25	$2.75	+$0.50
30-06 Springfield	$2.10	$2.55	+$0.45
308 Win	$2.10	$2.54	+$0.44
270 Win	$2.15	$2.50	+$0.35
6.5 Creedmoor	$2.05	$2.43	+$0.38
243 Win	$1.95	$2.35	+$0.40

The table highlights that entry costs depend heavily on the caliber itself. Historically popular cartridges like .243 Win, .308 Win, .270 and .30-06 Springfield - as well as more recent offerings including 6.5 Creedmoor - remain the most affordable overall, with the median price of lead-free loads around $2.50 per round.

Market Availability & Distinct Offerings

Overall Distinct Products Available



How to read this chart:

- **Bar Length:** The total length shows the approximate number of distinct factory choices a consumer has for that caliber.
  - *Note on data:* While offerings have been deduplicated using universal product codes (UPC) and manufacturer part numbers (MPN), minor overlap may persist due to variations in how individual retailers catalog products.
- **Color Split:** Each bar is divided into **Lead-Core (blue)** and **Lead-Free (orange)** segments, illustrating the relative product diversity between the two bullet types.

Takeaway: Choice is heavily concentrated in a handful of calibers. The .308 Win, 6.5 Creedmoor, and .30-06 Springfield calibers represent the vast majority of retail variety. While lead-free options are available in every key hunting caliber, they generally represent 15% to 25% of total product variety, with some calibers like .300 WSM and 7mm-08 Rem offering fewer than 15 unique non-lead loads.

Retailer-Level Availability

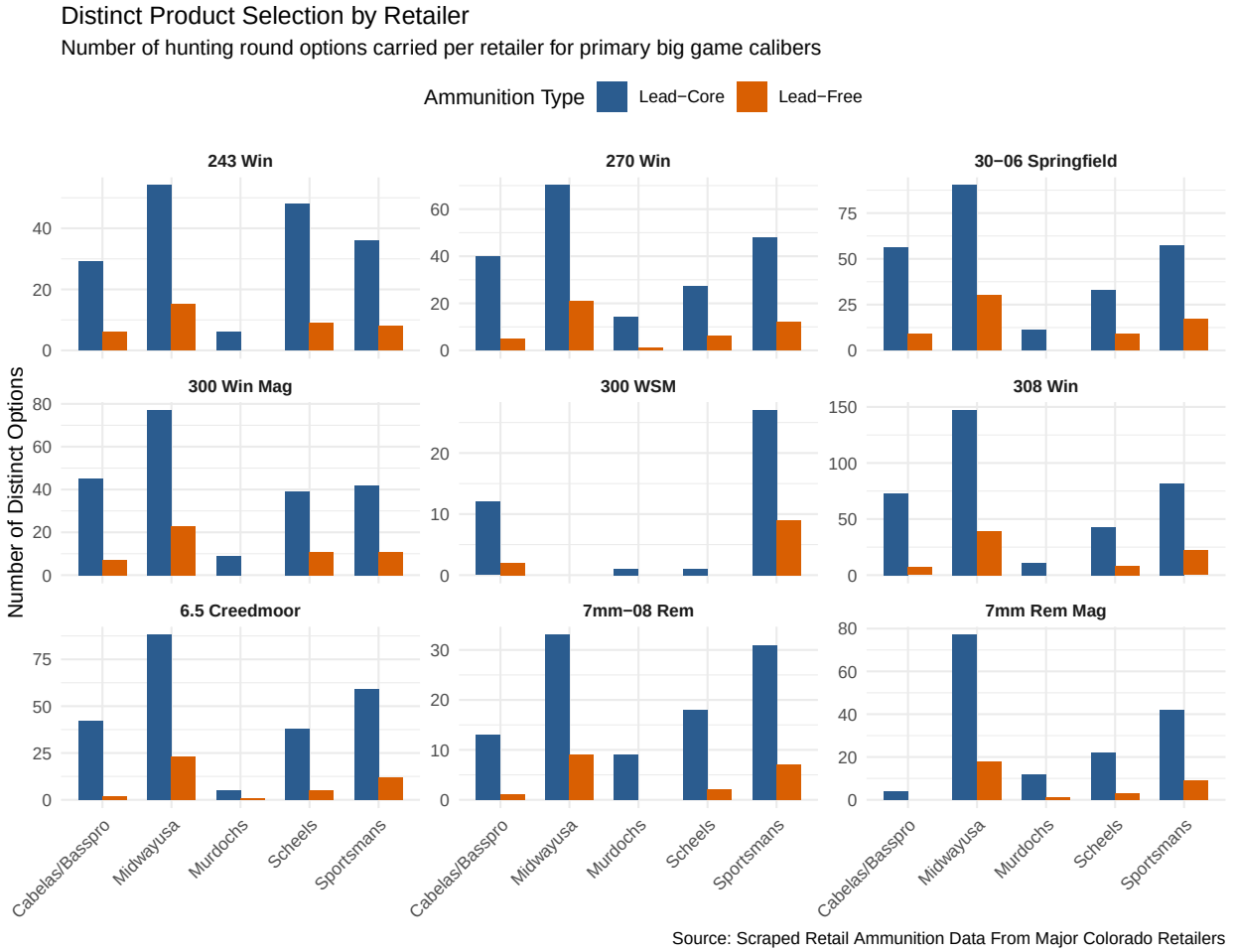
This section evaluates availability across individual storefronts - showing whether a hunter walking into a specific store or ordering from a specific retailer can reasonably expect to find lead-free choices.

Table 3: Average & Median Product Options Available Per Retailer

caliber	category	avg_options_per_retailer	median_options_per_retailer	retailers_stocking
243 Win	Lead-Core	34.6	36.0	5
243 Win	Lead-Free	9.5	8.5	4
270 Win	Lead-Core	39.8	40.0	5
270 Win	Lead-Free	9.0	6.0	5
30-06 Springfield	Lead-Core	49.4	56.0	5
30-06 Springfield	Lead-Free	16.2	13.0	4
300 WSM	Lead-Core	10.2	6.5	4
300 WSM	Lead-Free	5.5	5.5	2
300 Win Mag	Lead-Core	42.4	42.0	5
300 Win Mag	Lead-Free	13.0	11.0	4
308 Win	Lead-Core	71.2	73.0	5
308 Win	Lead-Free	19.0	15.0	4
6.5 Creedmoor	Lead-Core	46.4	42.0	5
6.5 Creedmoor	Lead-Free	8.6	5.0	5
7mm Rem Mag	Lead-Core	31.4	22.0	5

caliber	category	avg_options_per_retailer	median_options_per_retailer	retailers_stocking
7mm Rem Mag	Lead-Free	7.8	6.0	4
7mm-08 Rem	Lead-Core	20.8	18.0	5
7mm-08 Rem	Lead-Free	4.8	4.5	4

Availability: Lead vs. Lead-Free by Retailer



How to read this chart:

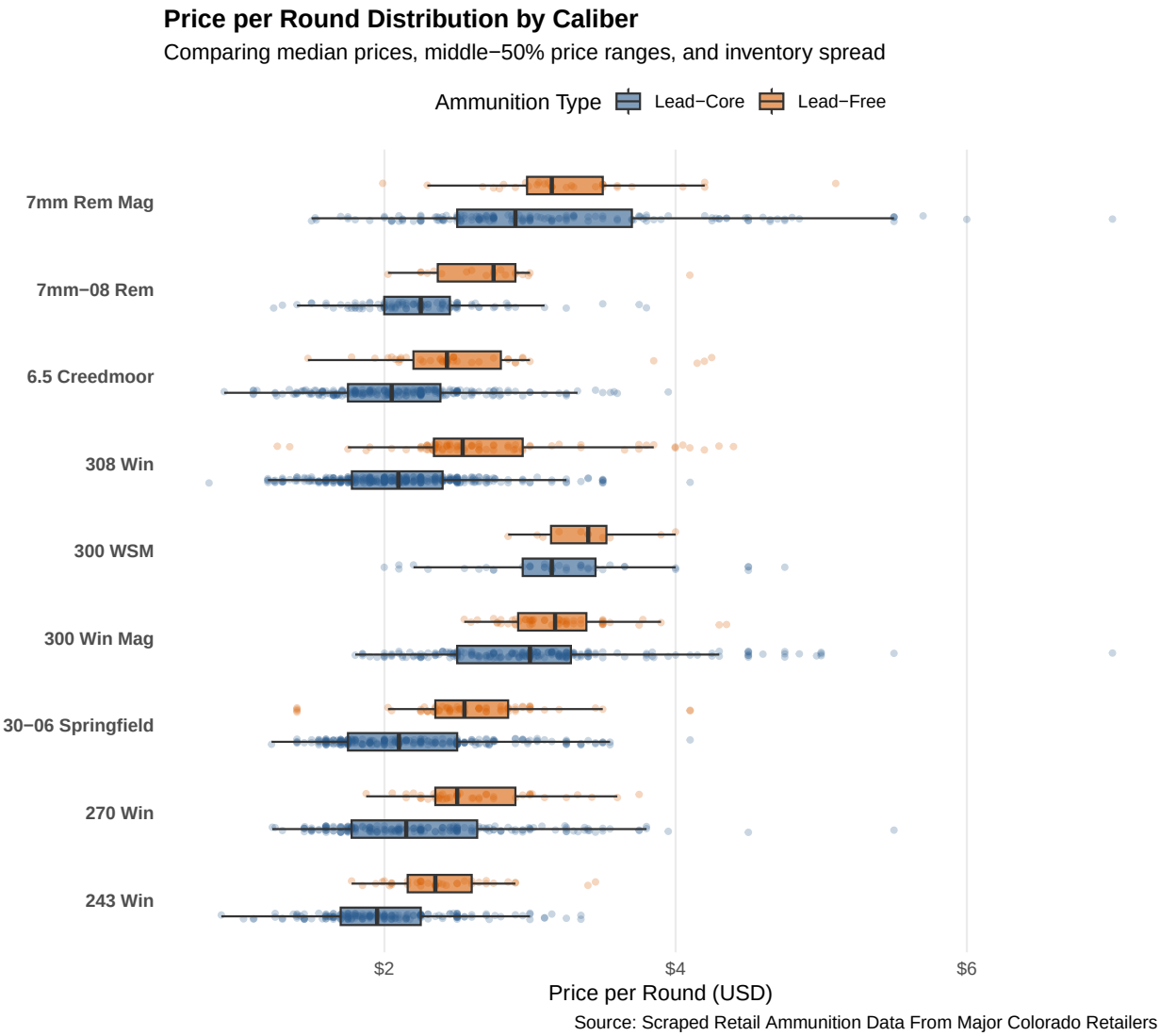
- Each panel represents one caliber.
- The x-axis lists the individual retailers surveyed.
- The height of the bars shows how many distinct boxes of ammunition that retailer has on offer for that caliber, directly comparing **traditional lead (blue)** against **lead-free (orange)**.

Takeaway: Retail depth varies widely. While larger sporting-goods chains and online-retailers stock broad selections of lead-core options (often 10 to 30 choices per caliber), lead-free availability at the store level is frequently limited to 1 to 4 SKUs per caliber, meaning hunters shopping locally have substantially fewer projectile weights and bullet designs to choose from.

Price Distributions: Where Do Shelf Prices Cluster?

Summary averages don't show whether options exist at budget price tiers or whether all lead-free offerings sit in the premium price bracket. The charts below display the full pricing spread across retailers.

Price Spread & Range (Box-and-Whisker)

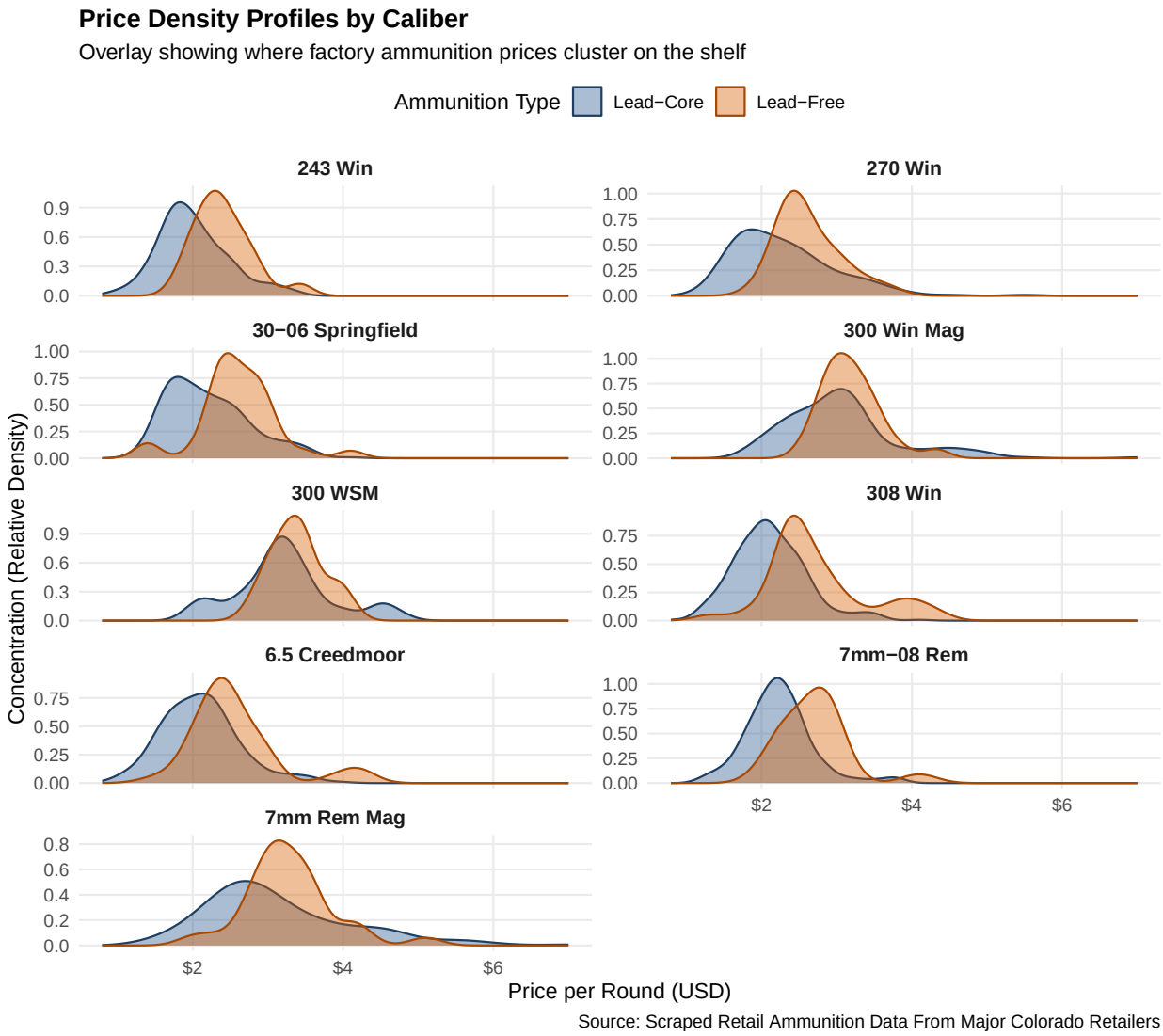


How to read this chart:

- **The shaded box:** Covers the middle 50% of ammo prices (the interquartile range). If a box is short, prices are very uniform; if it is long, prices vary widely.
- **The solid line inside the box:** The median price point.
- **The "whiskers" (lines extending outward):** Show the typical upper and lower price limits for that ammunition.
- **The faint dots:** Represent individual boxes of ammunition, showing where retailer inventory is thin or dense.

Takeaway: The entry price for lead-free ammunition is noticeably higher than lead-core. While traditional lead ammunition features inexpensive baseline hunting options starting around $1.25 to $1.75 per round, lead-free rarely dips below $2.10 to $2.25 per round. At the top end, premium lead-core loads (tipped, bonded, high BC) overlap heavily with standard lead-free offerings.

Price Density Profiles



Source: Scraped Retail Ammunition Data From Major Colorado Retailers

How to read this chart:

- Think of these curves as smooth hills showing **where products cluster along the price spectrum**.
- **High peaks:** Indicate a price point where many different products are available.
- **A curve shifted to the right:** Indicates that products in that category are systematically more expensive.
- **Overlapping shaded areas:** The price range where lead and lead-free options share the same price bracket.

Takeaway: Cartridges like .308 Win and 6.5 Creedmoor share a notable overlap under their curves, indicating that there are many lead-core and lead-free options sharing that price range. However, all calibers

indicate that lead-free option are shifted toward an overall higher price per round.